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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 5 Watoro's Story: Poverty Is Like Dust

After it was over, castor oil was put on a soft leaf, and it was put over the wound to cover it until it was healed. if a girl bled a lot the parents would decide what to do, because it meant there was a dispute between her parents and her uncles, and before it was solved—by slaughtering a goat—the girl would bleed. So uncles were given in advance the number of goats given for the mother of the initiate when she was married—that way there were no problems.

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On the way home, I walked slowly with no one to support me. There were so many people going with me, cheering and singing songs for me on the way to my mother's house, where sour porridge had already been prepared. But me, I was so weak and tired, I went straight to bed and slept.

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After three days, a small girl came and shaved my head, and from then we called each other "*Wamathaga*," which means that as you have shaved my head, you are my mother, and so I can't call you by your name—only *Wamathaga*. It took me a month and then another to heal completely.

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After it was over, I felt grown up and walked around proudly. When a girl got her ears pierced, then was circumcised, she was looked upon as a grown-up and was treated like one. No young boys would date joke about with her or abuse her, for the boy's father would beat him. Circumcised girls were very respected, and those who went for *lrúa* earlier than us, they were considered our mothers, and we would not disobey them or we would be beaten.

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The girls who are circumcised together, of the same age, are *riika* [agemates] and are friends always. We used to go to sleep at our house and other times at theirs, working in the *shamba* together and cooking soup for each other. After going through *lrúa*, we made beauty marks on our faces by rubbing ashes into cuts we made. We also made some on the breasts so that when dancing naked, the marks made our bodies more beautiful. That was our tradition. Later, some missionaries tried to stop traditions like this, but we

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said, "The one who puts on a dress and goes to school is a prostitute." My father refused to let me go to school, because he said I would become a prostitute. I never felt sad about not going to school. I was happy going to dances, because I was not alone.

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When I got my first menstruation after *Irua*, nobody had told me about it. I was scared when I first saw the blood, because I had never seen [120](#) it there before. I went to my mother, and she told me that it was normal and it was a sign that I'm a woman so I should start taking care of myself with men.

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